

The Round-up.

In the year 1868 (the year in which the county seat was located in Pendleton) the wild gold rush from the Willamette Valley to the Eastern Oregon mines had spent much of its force. True, for many years afterward, long lines of pack trains as well as oxen teams and all manner of freighting continued, but there was no longer the wild scramble to be first at the discoveries. The previous six years, however, had left an impression on Umatilla County. Among the places established were the Four-Mile House, Six-Mile House, Twelve-Mile House, the Old Wells Station, Happy Canyon, Gray Back Flat, Alta, Swift's Station, and Goodwin's Crossing.

The Four-Mile House was located at the bend of the Umatilla River four miles south of the town of Umatilla and on the main traveled road. It was first established by James Wardwell and was occupied by Cucos and then by D. Theodore. It was a way station where travelers stopped and where liquor was sold in quantities less than a quart.

The Six-Mile House was located two miles farther south on the road and was the exact site where Hermiston is now located. It was also a place where travelers stopped, where liquor was sold, and was occupied by D.I. Lansdale.

The Twelve-Mile House was still farther south on the main traveled road, located on the road and where Stanfield is now located. This was also a general stopping place and was operated by Wilson Whitworth and W. Bailey. One branch of the main traveled road left the Umatilla River at Twelve-Mile House, ran across the hills to the upper Umatilla. Upon this road, and about seven miles from the Twelve-Mile House, what was then known as Wells Station was located. The only water between the Twelve-Mile House and the upper Umatilla was obtained at

this station, where teams and pack trains often camped and secured water. A charge was made for watering teams at this station.

The other line of the road ran up the Umatilla River, on the east side, to a point where Echo now stands, where the Old Oregon Trail crossed the Umatilla River and then ran eastward across the hills to the upper Umatilla.

The large flat or tract of bottom land where Echo is now located and between the Umatilla River at that point and the hills was the camping ground for pack trains, freight teams, and immigrants, and would often have a population of from ten to thirty people camped there overnight with freight teams, pack trains, immigrants and general travelers. It was generally known in the early days as Gray Back Flat. Later, and before the establishment of the town of Echo, it was the most widely known and generally used round-up ground in the county, and in that vicinity became generally known and described as the Umatilla Round-up Ground, and was known by that name until the establishment of Echo. It acquired the name of Round-up Ground by reason of its use, and from the fact that at least once a year, and perhaps twice a year, once in the spring and once in the fall, herds of cattle and sometimes horses were gathered up from the surrounding territory, and driven to this point or flat for separation and delivery to the respective owners.

There were no buildings upon this flat east of the river, excepting a small log house, located at the extreme southern side of the flat. This house was owned and part of the time occupied by G.W. Palmer, a deputy sheriff under Sheriff Frank Maddock, who was with Sheriff Maddock at the time Hank Vaughn and his associates killed one deputy and seriously wounded Sheriff Maddock in an arrest made

on the Snake River for stealing of horses by Vaughn and his associates.

At that time there were no fences anywhere in the country except some tracts along the streams and river bottoms. It was a wide range, extending from Willow Creek on the west to the Walla Walla River on the east, from the Columbia River on the north to the foothills of the Blue Mountains on the south. Cattle and horses were generally kept within a reasonable distance of the owners' headquarters, but scattered and ranged and became mixed and comingled, one herd with another over a great portion of this territory just described.

The round-up originated by different districts in the territory forming groups of owners and employees of a certain district. The various groups, under the leadership of someone selected, would drive and converge over a certain portion of the territory, meeting at a given place known as the Round-up Grounds, where the stock so gathered would be separated, each owner taking his own back to his range. The various brands of all persons joining at the round-up would be known, and stock which was found off the home range was driven to the round-up and separated.

The Round-up at Echo usually contained the largest gathering of stock and riders, all herds being centered at the round-up at practically a certain day named and known to the riders.

Another principal round-up ground was located on Butter Creek near the forks and others of lesser importance at various points on Willow Creek and the Columbia River, Birch Creek, and the lower Walla Walla River.

In conducting these round-ups, each district, or foreman, had its own outfit, its own chuck wagon and camped separately, but of course, in the immediate vicinity of each

other at the Round-up Grounds. Smaller and lesser outfits often traveled with one or two pack animals instead of a chuck wagon.

The day of the separation, each owner's stock was taken from the main herd that was in the round-up, delivered to him or his riders, and taken back to his home ranch or range. It was not unusual at these round-ups for the branding and marking of calves to take place. The branded cows with calves were usually marked and branded in corals or small enclosures.

At the general camp, and after the congregation of the riders, occasionally a wild horse would be ridden, occasionally some pony races would take place, and frequently a maverick or slick ear would be butchered from the herd and the meat distributed among the various camps.

At the annual round-up at the Umatilla Round-up Grounds, there would occasionally be as many as fifteen or twenty men, and perhaps two to three hundred head of cattle. The riders during the round-up would often ride wild and unbroken horses, but usually at camp and after the day's work was done. Each rider had his own cow horse or horses, in which they took great pride, and were well-trained in the handling and separation of cattle.

From these ancient round-ups, and especially the old Umatilla round-up, then conducted where Echo now stands, the present world-wide famous and spectacular round-up adopted its name, hence Pendleton Round-up.

In 1867, license to conduct a ferry at a point about three-fourths of a mile above where Stanfield is now located was issued to N.B. Evans, and during the same year, similar license to operate a ferry was issued to John Bradburn, who was authorized to operate such ferry where "the old Dalles road now crosses the Umatilla" being at the point

and practically the identical place where the new county bridge at Echo is now located.

A Roadhouse at the Fort Henrietta Site
Allphin-Bradburn Roadhouse, ca. 1858-1870

The Fort Henrietta-Utilla Indian Agency Site remained deserted for only two years. According to the reminiscences of Ella Ann McClain Allphin Burbank, she and her first husband, Marion Allphin, used a structure(s) at the fort site between 1858 and early 1862 as a roadhouse on the old immigrant road. They supplied travelers with supplies and, lacking a stove, cooked meals for the immigrants over an open fire. The enterprise ceased following Mr. Allphin's death when he became lost during a blizzard in 1862 on the way to The Dalles to buy provisions. The Chapman Survey Map of 1859 doesn't specifically identify the Allphin roadhouse, but noted at the location "the Agency,"

Allphin's successor was John P Bradburn who may have assumed operation of a roadhouse at the site in 1862. In 1867 he obtained a Umatilla County license to operate a trading post and ferry at the Umatilla River crossing but he may have been licensed to Wasco County earlier or did business without a formal license. By the early 1870s the roadhouse appears to no longer have been in business and the land was used for ranching by local businessman W.W. Leezer.

During the 1860s a significant back migration occurred on the Oregon Trail route with ranchers returning from the Willamette Valley to the fabled grasslands of Eastern Oregon. Added to this was the eastward travel of miners and others attracted by the discovery of the Idaho and Eastern Oregon gold fields. Leaving the Columbia

River at the Dalles or Umatilla Landing these travelers, passing over the well-established immigrant routes arrived at the old Umatilla Crossing.

The roadhouse provided, as had the earlier Uilla Agency, a safe resting place where water, supplies and meals were available for both the west and east bound travelers. Archaeological excavations at the site have recovered artifacts including sherds of white ironstone china and black glass whiskey bottles, ammunition and other artifacts attributed to this period. In the early 1870s W. W. Leezer claimed the location and probably used it for stock-raising until he platted it as the West Lawn residential development in 1905.

The roadhouse structure after 1870 was used as a local meeting hall for several years and may have been fortified during the 1878 Bannock Indian War when many ranching families concentrated for protection. The remnants of the structure were no longer standing or were obliterated when Leezer Street was platted at the site in 1905 and no photographs have been found showing the building. During the early 20th century, however, the old log roadhouse was remembered as a “blockhouse” and attributed by some local residents to Fort Henrietta. The widowed Mrs. Allphin, her two young daughters and a nephew had moved from the area and their early roadhouse was not remembered in historic accounts of Umatilla County written after 1900.

The Echo Story Begins.
Chapter 9
The Beginnings of the Town.

In 1879, it would be three years before the Oregon Rail and Navigation Line finished its planned railroad linking Pendleton and Portland. However, anticipating the business opportunities that would arise from the new line, J. H. Koontz constructed a store near a north-south stretch of track at the future site of "Echo City." He named the location after his daughter (The area had, for a time, been known as Grayback Flat). The frame-built store was northwest of the old emigrant trail at Umatilla Crossing (the old 76 service station building is on this site), which led to Umatilla Meadows, where ranches had been established following the Civil War. An earlier settlement with a general store, called Evertsville, existed nearby on the Umatilla Meadows, but was doomed by the founding of Echo. The location of Koontz's store was, ultimately, to be near the center of the town's commercial district, where an important road bridge was also planned to cross the Umatilla River. (Just twenty-three years before, the Fort Henrietta log stockade had briefly existed directly across the river.)

In October of 1881, the *East Oregonian* announced that 'We learn that the bridge on the Umatilla at Echo has been completed and is now ready for use. It is a single span of 112 feet and is said to be the best piece of such architecture in the County.' Although it would be another year before the railroad arrived, Echo's central location was of growing importance, and 1882 was a year of significant commercial growth for the town. By the end of the year, two hotels, two blacksmiths, a post office, two feed stables, a livery barn, two stores, two saloons, a wagon maker, two butcher shops, a carpenter shop, a furniture store, and about 25 dwellings had been built. A new schoolhouse was the site of a social dance on May 26. The structure, measuring 40 by 24 feet, also served as a community church. The first class opened with 32 students. Also during May, William Voss was reportedly expanding his 'Farmer's Home Saloon' to include a billiard table, as a competitor, J. Sullivan (Sullivan), was building a rival saloon and business house. Echo lots were in demand, and cost about \$100.

Life in Echo also reflected its emerging reputation as a sometimes-violent boomtown in the developing frontier of Eastern Oregon. In June, 1882, the *East Oregonian* colorfully reported that 'A stranger went into a saloon yesterday and drank a large amount of 'coffin varnish', became very boisterous and entered Mr. Koontz's store

and stole a pair of boots. He says he intends to steal until he goes to the penitentiary. He is still at large.' Although the citizens of Echo were faced with the occasional crime, the community did not hire a town marshal during the town's first years.

The same day a news report noted that 'Wool is still being piled up at Echo.' E. Meeker had advertised in May that he would buy wool for cash. J. H. Koontz also shipped wool from Echo as well as running his store and a hotel on the second story. His partner W. W. Brassfield was operating a feed yard and livery stable.

During the construction of the rail line, the track laying and roadbed construction was done under the supervision of largely Irish section bosses. During the week before Christmas 1882, Mike O'Donnell, section boss at Echo, had his skull fractured when another section man hit him with a shovel. According to the *East Oregonian*, O'Donnell 'gave his assailant as good as he sent. O'Donnell walked into Echo and had his wounds dressed by Dr. Brownell and was sent to Portland for further repairs, as a trepanning operation was necessary. The other fellow was taken to Umatilla on a hand cart.'